

**AUGUST 2026**  
MONTHLY NEWSLETTER

# A MONTH OF BIG SHIFTS

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## Tamil Nadu Scraps ₹20 Crore Parandur Airport Project After Years of Protests

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay has announced the scrapping of the proposed ₹20,000 crore second Chennai airport at Parandur in Kancheepuram district, bringing an end to a project that had faced years of environmental concerns and local protests. The airport was originally announced in 2022, around 60 km from Chennai, with a proposed capacity of 100 million passengers annually. However, residents opposed the project, arguing that acquiring agricultural land would threaten their livelihoods and damage important water bodies and the area's ecology. Vijay, who had joined the Parandur protests in January 2025 before coming to power, said his government would prioritise environmental protection while searching for alternative sites for Chennai's future second airport. Meanwhile, the government plans to significantly expand the existing Chennai International Airport at Meenambakkam. Once Terminal 3 is completed, its capacity is expected to reach 35 million passengers annually. With the proposed Terminal 5, total capacity could eventually increase to 55 million passengers per year. Additional access roads, flyovers and infrastructure improvements are also planned to manage growing passenger and cargo traffic until a new second airport is developed.



## Iran Threatens to Halt Persian Gulf Oil Exports Amid US Economic Pressure

Iran has warned that "not a single drop of oil" would be exported from the Persian Gulf if the United States continues what Tehran describes as an economic war against the country. The warning came from Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, as Washington prepares to introduce fresh sanctions targeting Iran and countries continuing to conduct business with Tehran. Rezaei said that if the economic pressure continues, oil exports could be stopped through both the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz and elsewhere in the Persian Gulf. He also warned that Iran would consider participation by other countries in America's economic campaign against Tehran as an "act of war." The threat carries major implications for global energy markets because the Strait of Hormuz is one of the world's most important oil transit routes, connecting Persian Gulf producers with international markets.



# WORLD 2.0



## Ajit Doval Heads to Beijing for 25th Round of India-China Boundary Talks

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval is scheduled to visit Beijing for talks with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi under the India-China Special Representatives mechanism, as both countries seek to maintain peace along their disputed border and improve bilateral relations. The 25th round of Special Representatives talks is scheduled for Tuesday and will focus on the long-standing boundary dispute along the approximately 3,488-km India-China border. Doval and Wang are the designated Special Representatives of their respective countries for these negotiations. Established in 2003, the mechanism was created to comprehensively address the boundary question. Although it has yet to produce a final settlement, it remains an important diplomatic channel for managing border tensions and maintaining communication between New Delhi and Beijing. The timing of the meeting is particularly significant as it comes ahead of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on September 12 and 13.



## Iran Reportedly Invited to Join Saudi-Pak-Turkey Mecca Defence Pact

Iran has reportedly been invited to join the Mecca Defence Pact, a newly formed defence alliance involving Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey, potentially signalling a major shift in regional security cooperation. The reported invitation is particularly significant because of the long-standing rivalry between Iran and Saudi Arabia, as well as Tehran's regional alliances. According to Al Mayadeen, Iranian parliamentary media official Mehdi Rahimi said Iran had received an invitation and was reviewing the proposal. However, the development has not yet been officially confirmed by Iran's Foreign Ministry or the three existing pact members. Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement on August 7, 2026. Its central principle states that an armed attack on any one member would be considered an attack on all three.



## India Marks National Space Day, Celebrating Three Years of Chandrayaan-3

India is celebrating National Space Day 2026, marking three years since the historic Chandrayaan-3 mission successfully landed on the Moon on August 23, 2023. The mission's Vikram lander achieved a safe soft landing near the lunar south polar region, making India the fourth country to soft-land on the Moon and the first to reach the vicinity of its southern polar region. The achievement established India as a major force in global space exploration. To commemorate this milestone, the Government of India designated August 23 as National Space Day, with the first celebration taking place in 2024. The occasion recognises not only Chandrayaan-3's success but also India's broader achievements in space science, research and technology. As India observes National Space Day in 2026, attention is increasingly shifting from what Chandrayaan-3 achieved to what it made possible.



# EDUCATION

## NIELIT Launches Cyber Kushti 2026, National Cybersecurity and AI Hackathon



The National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (NIELIT) has launched Cyber Kushti 2026, a national-level cybersecurity and Artificial Intelligence hackathon aimed at identifying and recognising talent in cyber defence and AI. According to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, the competition is designed to test human judgement and decision-making in cybersecurity assessment, giving participants an opportunity to demonstrate their analytical and technical capabilities. Registration for Cyber Kushti 2026 is free and open to students and independent researchers, who can participate in teams of three. The registration window will remain open until September 10, 2026. Adding an Indian cultural identity to the technology competition, the winning team will receive the prestigious title "Cyber Kesari 2026" along with a traditional Gada (गदा).

## School Audit Campaign Turns Deadly in W.B. After Activist's Father Dies



A campaign highlighting conditions in India's government-run schools has taken a tragic turn in Bankura, West Bengal, after the father of a 26-year-old activist reportedly died following an alleged assault. On August 13, Abdul Hafeez visited his former primary school in Karisunda village as part of an education audit campaign organised by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), a pressure group campaigning for improvements in underfunded government schools. Hafeez alleged that hours after the visit, local individuals he identified as BJP workers came to his home and assaulted him and his father, Mohammad Mafik. His 51-year-old father reportedly died from his injuries two days later. The case has brought renewed attention to two major issues: the condition of government-run schools and allegations of political violence surrounding grassroots activism.

## Yuva Sangam Phase VII Registration Extended Till August 31



The Ministry of Education has extended the online registration deadline for Yuva Sangam Phase VII from August 18 to August 31, 2026, giving young people across India additional time to participate in the national youth exchange programme. Youth aged 18 to 30 years are eligible to apply, including students from higher education institutions, NSS volunteers and young professionals. Applications can be submitted through the official Yuva Sangam portal. For Phase VII, 20 higher education institutions, including IITs, IIMs, Central Universities and NITs, have been selected as nodal institutions to coordinate the programme. Selected participants will undertake five to seven-day educational and cultural tours to paired States and Union Territories. The initiative aims to strengthen connections among young Indians from different regions by encouraging cultural exchange, experiential learning and greater understanding of India's diversity.



# SPORTS



## Inaugural Esports Nations Cup Postponed to November 2027

The Esports Foundation (EF) has postponed the inaugural Esports Nations Cup (ENC) from November 2026 to November 2027 following a review of the broader regional situation and discussions with key stakeholders. The international esports tournament was originally scheduled to take place in Riyadh in November 2026. According to the Foundation, the decision to delay the event was influenced by uncertainty surrounding the regional context and the unprecedented international scale of the competition. EF said postponing the tournament was the most responsible option to provide greater certainty, stability and preparation time for participating national teams, game publishers, commercial partners and esports fans. The Esports Nations Cup is intended to bring national teams together on a major international competitive platform.



## India Strengthens Badminton Partnership as New Delhi Hosts BWF WC-2026

Union Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya met Badminton World Federation President Khunying Patama Leeswadtrakul in New Delhi to discuss strengthening India's partnership with the international governing body for badminton. The meeting comes as India hosts the prestigious BWF World Championships 2026 in New Delhi from August 17 to 23, bringing many of the world's leading badminton players to the country. Discussions focused on India's growing role in international badminton and opportunities to expand cooperation with the BWF. Hosting a tournament of this scale also highlights India's increasing capability to organise major global sporting events. Meanwhile, Indian shuttlers have experienced mixed results during the opening three days of the championships as they compete against the world's best players.



## ISL 2026-27 Confirmed With 13 Clubs After Jamshedpur FC Exit

The All India Football Federation (AIFF) has confirmed that the Indian Super League (ISL) 2026-27 season will feature 13 clubs, with the competition continuing in a double round-robin format. Each team will play opponents both at home and away. The season's official kick-off date and complete fixture list have not yet been announced. AIFF said further details will be released in due course. Finalising the number of participating clubs will now allow organisers to proceed with commercial discussions and fixture planning. The confirmation follows Jamshedpur FC's withdrawal from the ISL ahead of the 2026-27 season. The decision was announced last month by Jamshedpur Football and Sporting Private Limited (JFSPL), the Tata Steel-owned company responsible for operating the club.



# TECHNOLOGY



## Unitree Unveils High-Speed "Superman" Robot Ahead of Historic Stock Market

Chinese robotics company Unitree has unveiled a new high-performance humanoid robot nicknamed "Superman", just days before the company is set to begin trading on the Shanghai stock market. The Hangzhou-based company, described as the world's largest humanoid robot manufacturer by sales, raised approximately 6.1 billion yuan (\$905 million) through its initial public offering. Its shares are scheduled to start trading in Shanghai on Wednesday, making Unitree the first general-purpose robotics company to list on mainland China's stock market. Unitree said its latest robot was developed in just over three months, highlighting the rapid pace of innovation within China's increasingly competitive robotics industry.



## Skyroot's Vikram-1 Marks Historic Milestone for India's Private Space Sector

After nearly six months of silence at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota, India's space industry witnessed a historic breakthrough with the successful launch of Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 rocket under Mission Aagaman. The launch ended a period during which no rockets had lifted off from the spaceport, raising concerns over delayed missions and the slowdown of India's space programme. Unlike previous landmark launches such as Chandrayaan-3 and Aditya-L1, this mission was not led by ISRO. Instead, it was carried out by Hyderabad-based private space startup Skyroot Aerospace, making Vikram-1 India's first privately developed orbital-class rocket to successfully reach orbit. As countdown clocks resumed and the launch complex came alive, engineers, scientists and millions of viewers witnessed a defining moment for India's growing commercial space ecosystem.



## Menzies Aviation Tests AI Powered Cargo Handling at London Heathrow

Menzies Aviation has launched a proof of concept trial of AI powered cargo measurement and monitoring technology at London Heathrow Airport, aiming to improve the speed, accuracy and safety of air cargo operations. The trial is being conducted with computer vision specialist CIND and focuses on automating cargo measurement, improving real time visibility and detecting potential loading problems earlier in the handling process. As part of the trial, Menzies is using CIND's Dimensioner In-Motion technology, which automatically measures cargo while it moves through the warehouse. The Heathrow trial highlights how AI and computer vision are increasingly moving into physical airport operations, potentially transforming traditionally manual cargo handling into a more automated and data driven process.



# ENTERTAINMENT



## Tom Holland's Spider-Man Payday Could Cross \$100 Million as Film Hits \$2.22B

Tom Holland's return as Peter Parker in *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* is proving to be one of the most lucrative decisions of his career. The actor reportedly earned \$20 million upfront for the film, double his reported pay for *Spider-Man: No Way Home*. But Holland's earnings may not stop there. His deal reportedly includes backend bonuses linked to the movie's box-office performance, potentially pushing his total compensation beyond \$100 million. The possibility is being fuelled by the film's extraordinary commercial performance. As of August 24, 2026, *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* has grossed approximately \$2.22 billion worldwide, including about \$855 million from the US and Canada and roughly \$1.36 billion from international markets. With *Brand New Day* continuing its blockbuster theatrical run, both its worldwide box-office total and Holland's potential final payday could climb even higher.



## Nagarjuna Says Dubbed Telugu Films Made Him More Popular in North India

Veteran actor Nagarjuna has revealed that his biggest breakthrough among Hindi-speaking audiences did not come from Bollywood films such as *Shiva* or *Khuda Gawah*, but from Hindi-dubbed versions of his Telugu movies. Speaking to *Variety India*, Nagarjuna identified *Mass*, released in Hindi as *Meri Jung: One Man Army*, and *Don*, popularly aired as *Don No. 1*, as two films that became exceptionally popular across North India. According to the actor, these dubbed films achieved greater recognition among Hindi-speaking audiences than many of the original Hindi movies he appeared in. He said fans frequently approach him in places such as Delhi, Kullu-Manali and Goa and specifically mention these films.



## Mukesh Khanna : Wants Vande Mataram as India's National Anthem

Actor-producer Mukesh Khanna, known for *Shaktimaan* and *Mahabharat*, has triggered controversy by calling for "Vande Mataram" to replace "Jana Gana Mana" as India's national anthem. Khanna argued that the continuing controversy surrounding *Vande Mataram* is unnecessary and reiterated his belief that *Jana Gana Mana* should not be the country's national anthem. He claimed that the song was written during British rule and suggested that the words "Jana Gana Mana Adhinayak" referred to British monarch King George V as the ruler determining India's destiny. His remarks revive a long-running debate surrounding the historical context of Rabindranath Tagore's composition. However, the claim that *Jana Gana Mana* was written in praise of George V has been widely disputed.



# REAL-ESTATE



## ED Attaches ₹129.80 Crore Properties in Ahmedabad Real Estate Fraud Case

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has provisionally attached immovable properties worth ₹129.80 crore in connection with an alleged real estate fraud that reportedly targeted hundreds of homebuyers and investors in Ahmedabad. The action was taken by the ED's Ahmedabad Zonal Office under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. The investigation involves Ronak Ravjibhai Sonani, Vipulbhai Gordhanbhai Gangani, Keshav Narayan Group and others, and stems from five FIRs registered at different police stations in Ahmedabad.



## Uttar Pradesh Real Estate Investment Jumps 53% to ₹68,328 Crore

Uttar Pradesh's real estate sector recorded strong growth in 2025, with capital investment rising 53% to ₹68,328 crore, according to data highlighted by UP RERA. This compares with ₹44,526 crore in 2024 and ₹28,411 crore in 2023. The momentum has continued into 2026. During the first six months of 2026, the state attracted nearly ₹32,000 crore across 158 real estate projects, representing approximately 46,000 housing units. Growth is also spreading beyond the traditional Delhi NCR market.

## Nisus Finance Launches \$50 Million Tokenised Real Estate Investment Offering

Nisus Finance Services Co Ltd has entered blockchain-based institutional real estate investing with the launch of NIFCOT1, its first tokenised offering backed by the Nisus High Yield Growth Fund. The inaugural issuance is valued at \$50 million and consists of 100,000 digital ownership tokens. It represents the first tranche of a larger \$500 million roadmap focused on regulated real-world asset (RWA) tokenisation. NIFCOT1 is structured through a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) and listed on the Toyow Marketplace, operated by Xchain Technologies FZCO. It provides tokenised economic exposure to the Nisus High Yield Growth Fund, which is regulated by the Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC) and invests in completed.



SUMIT BHRIYA  
Co-founder & CEO  
**BRICKHILL GROUP**

### Message from Director's Desk

#### *A Choice That Shapes Our Cities*

India's rapid urban growth has created major real estate opportunities, but it has also exposed the risks of unauthorized and unplanned development. Authorities are increasingly acting against projects built without proper approvals, infrastructure and planning standards. Unauthorized developments often lack adequate parking, proper roads, drainage, sewage systems, water supply, electricity and basic amenities. Over time, these shortcomings create congestion, strain civic infrastructure and increase uncertainty for residents and investors. In contrast, planned and RERA-approved developments provide regulatory compliance, transparent documentation, defined layouts, planned infrastructure and committed amenities. They are designed not just for construction today, but for sustainable living tomorrow.

*Real estate should create lasting value, not future uncertainty.*

